



Sports Talk

with
Bill Carter



Sports Are Fun

(While Bill Carter is on vacation, his column will be written by sports publicists and news bureau chiefs of colleges and universities in Louisiana.)

BY PAUL MANASSEH
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Sports is fun.
Or is that ungrammatical?
Maybe it should be sports are fun.
Tennyrate, after spending some one-third of a century in athletics, both professional and amateur, I'm convinced that the old adage "you meet such interesting people in the newspaper business" isn't quite true.

I think the most interesting, the most fascinating people travel through the sports pages.

A Joe Namath captures the imagination of a nation through his exploits on the gridiron, then astounds the public with his unorthodox behavior off the field. A Jim Bouton spends a major league baseball career as just a journeyman ball player, then writes a book which dispels ancient illusions about the infallibility of diamond performers; a Bill Veeck sets attendance records as a major league owner, attempts new approaches to tried and true practices and is banished from the major league scene only to return to resurrect a dying horse track in a Boston suburb; a Charlie McClendon is pegged as another somebody-or-other and takes several years to establish himself as an individual coach with superb talents.

There are a few disturbing elements too.

SPORTS PRODUCES LAUGHS

A Denny McLain is slapped on the wrist when a much more severe penalty is indicated; a Brian Piccolo dies before his time, felled by the dread disease, cancer; a Dave Hill voices his opinion and is fined \$150 for daring to; a \$90,000 a year ball player threatens to upset the status quo of America's erstwhile national pastime and businessmen posing as sportsmen raise ugly threats of what it will do to baseball.

But taken in the whole, sports produces more laughs than all the comics who perform along the Las Vegas strip.

I once was associated with a great football player named Carlton Chester (Cookie) Gilchrist whose escapades and militancy (before that word meant what it means today) kept him in hot water. A sports writer once asked one of Cookie's coaches if the fullback could be described as a "Jekyll and Hyde?" The coach thought a moment and replied: "Absolutely not, one of those guys was a good guy."

Mark Freeman was a former LSU baseball and basketball star who signed with the New York Yankees. He rose to AAA baseball with Denver in the American Association, and once, starting against Charleston, he walked the first five men to face him. John Blanchard, later a star receiver for the Yankees, was catching and he called time, walked to the mound, and said: "Hey, Freeman, if the fix is on, let me in on it."

When Rogers Hornsby was in his prime he was hitting against a rookie pitcher whose first two tosses were called balls by the umpire Bill Klem. The hurler complained about both of them, but Mr. Klem ignored him. On the third pitch, Hornsby aced it into left center and he was rounding first, heading for second, Mr. Klem stalked in front of the plate and hollered to the dejected pitcher: "When it's a strike, Mr. Hornsby will let you know."

Somebody once asked Charlie

McClendon what was the best pass defense. Cholly Mac, without a moment's hesitation replied: "a four touchdown lead."

A few years ago Buddy Blair, the former LSU star and Hall of Fame member, managed the Alexandria Aces. His team blew a seven run lead in the last inning and Buddy was beside himself. Finally, he called Salty Parker, then managing the parent Shreveport team, itself a cellar occupant, and said "Salty, what do you do when you have a seven run lead in the ninth inning and can't hold it?"

"Don't ask me," Parker wearily replied. "I've never had a seven run lead."

Speaking of blowing leads, in 1960, the first year of the American Football League, games were high scoring affairs. Buffalo led Denver 38-7 with four minutes left in the third quarter when the Broncos suddenly got hot and the game ended in a 38-38 tie. Buster Ramsey, coaching the Bills, was riding to the airport in a cab with a sports writer who asked him how he took a game like that.

TOO LATE TO WORRY

"You don't worry about it," said Buster. "You forget about it. There's nothing you can do about it after it's over, you just look ahead to next week."

As he was talking he was pouring a shot of booze from a bottle, aiming for a paper cup in his other hand, but missing and pouring the liquid into his lap!

Andy Cohen was a likeable sort who managed a number of minor league teams after his playing career ended. However, Andy recalled a favorite story which happened back in the days when he was with the old New York Giants who were managed by the legendary Muggsy McGraw. Once playing a game in Irish-dominated Boston, Freddie Fitzsimmons, pitching for the Giants, was lifted for a pinch hitter who happened to be Cohen. The public address announcer intoned: "Cohen now batting for Fitzsimmons."

With that a red-faced immigrant from Ireland stood up behind the dugout and at the top of his lungs, yelled: "And Harrigan now leaving the ball park!"

HERE'S THE FOOTBALL

Remember the time a football coach, at the opening of fall practice, held a pigskin aloft and said to his assembled hopefuls: "Now men, this is a football."

From the back of the room came the plaintive plea: "Not so fast, coach."

Or the time the two professional basketball players were waiting for a game in the locker room when one of them said: "I have an awful time, remembering names."

The other said: "Me, too, until I took that Sam Carnegie course."

And there was Vernon Gomez, "El Goofy" of the fabulous Yankees. Lefty once said that if it hadn't been for his pitching, no one would have ever known if Joe DiMaggio could go back for a fly ball, saying "I never saw anything of Joe except the back of his uniform."

Gomez, whose exploits belied his wit, has a 6-0 mark in World Series pitching decisions. Someone once asked him after he had finished his career if he thought anyone would break the mark.

"I don't see how," Lefty opined. "I'm not going to lose any."